SEARCH AND DESTROY TACTICS

US ground forces took the offensive in South Vietnam, aiming to "find, fix, and destroy" the enemy. Typically, a company would be airlifted by helicopter into a part of the jungle where communist troops were known to be operating. The area around the designated landing zone (LZ) would be "prepped" by air strikes or by artillery fire from the nearest firebase before the helicopters were sent in. Either alone or alongside other units in a wider sweep, the company would then move on foot through the forest seeking contact with enemy infantry.

AIR AND ARTILLERY SUPPORT

When a firefight began, the American infantry would call in artillery fire and air strikes to hammer the enemy position. Efforts to surround enemy formations generally failed. The agile communists were expert at filtering through any attempted encirclement, and at ambushing reinforcements moving up to join the combat. The awesome firepower at the Americans' disposal, especially from the air, ensured that many more Viet Cong and NVA troops died than US soldiers. On the other hand, the grunt on the ground frequently found himself fighting at a disadvantage, facing a numerically far superior enemy.

belonging to the 26th Marine Regiment. The NVA force that surrounded the base was probably 40,000-strong. The NVA dug trenches to within 90m (100yd) of the perimeter of sandbags and barbed wire but failed to take the base by assault. On the other hand, the Marines had severe difficulties keeping the garrison supplied by air. The base's airstrip was exposed to enemy mortar and artillery fire and anti-aircraft guns menaced the approaches to the base. Air operations were also rendered hazardous by persistent low cloud. The American nightmare was that the base would be overrun or forced to surrender, as had happened to the French at the hands of the Viet Minh at Dien Bien Phu in 1954. There was a tremor of anxiety when, during the siege, an American outpost at Lang Vei was overrun by the NVA using tanks. But the Marines held on at Khe Sanh and at their surrounding hill-top outposts until a relief column broke through on 8 April. The Marines had lost 199 dead and 830 wounded in the siege.



US Army note pad
During the Vietnam War much of a Marine's equipment, despite rivalry, was US Army-issue.

While the siege of Khe Sanh was going on, the communists launched the Tet Offensive (during the Tet holiday celebrations) in which they attempted to seize control of cities and towns across South Vietnam. While most urban areas were held or swiftly retaken by US and South Vietnamese forces, the city of Hue was held by NVA soldiers for 25 days. The Marines played the leading part in wresting back control of the city. They fought from house to house and from street to street, at one point reportedly taking a casualty for every yard of ground gained. By the time NVA resistance finally ceased on 24 February, the Marines had lost almost a thousand men killed or wounded.

CRISIS OF MORALE

At Khe Sanh and at Hue the grunts had shown all the qualities expected of US Marines. Many men had been driven to the limits of endurance; war correspondents described the "thousand-yard stare" of the soldier reduced to mental and emotional blankness by the stress of sustained

On patrol
Captain Charles Robb leads a group of Marines on patrol south of Da Nang in May 1968. Patrols were usually made in platoon (20-man) or company (100-man) strength.



Cooking equipment
Most of a Marine's food came in cans. After eating, cutlery was slid onto the pan handle through holes at their ends to keep them together while being washed.

TIN PAN FOR COOKING AND EATING

CUTLERY